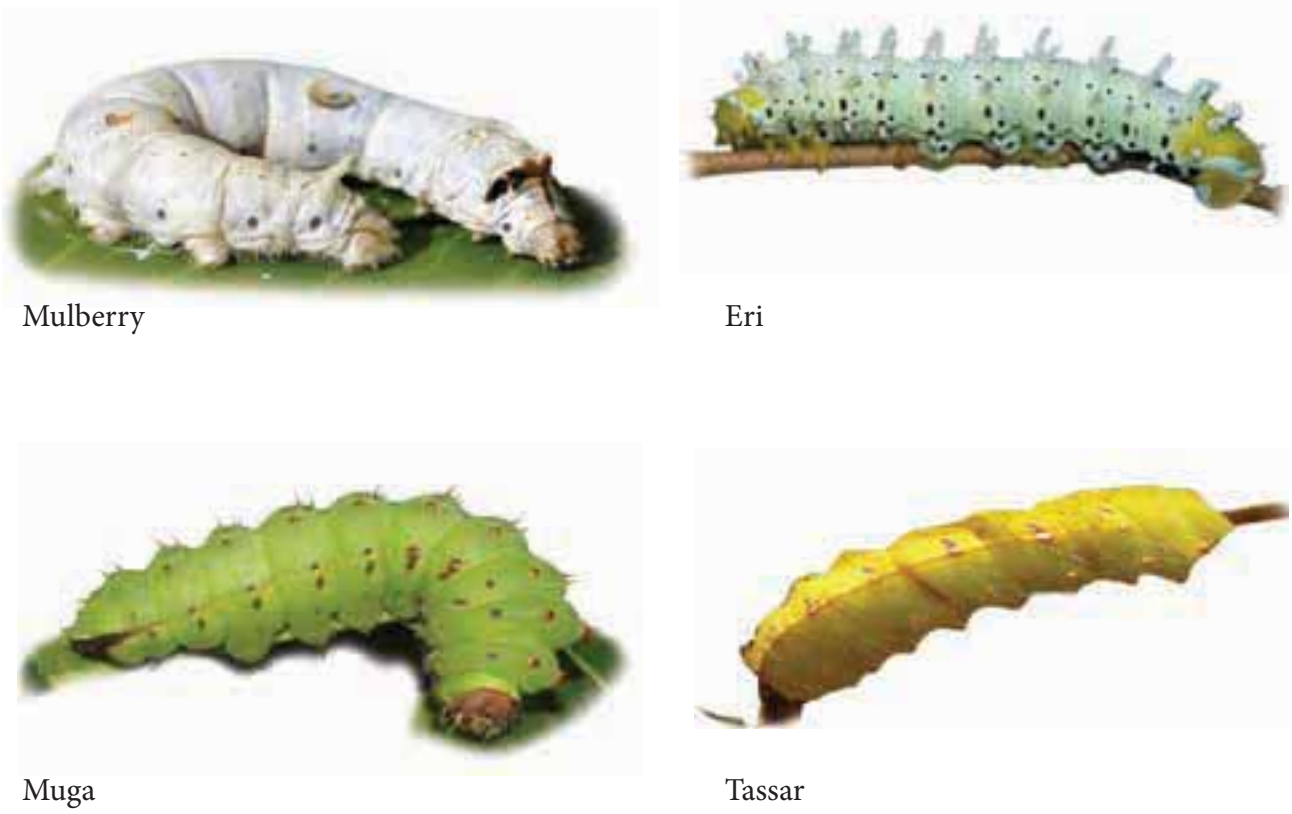
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practiced in China long back and they preserved the secret for more than 3000 years and maintained monopoly in silk trade with the rest of the world. According to Western historians, mulberry cultivation spread to India about 140BC from China through Tibet. The fabulous silk from China and India were carried to European countries. The 7000 mile lengthy road, historically called the "**Silk road**" passing through Baghdad, Tashkent, Damascus and Istanbul was used for silk transport. Today more than 29 countries in the world are practicing sericulture and producing different kinds of silk. India stands second in silk production next to China.

Production of silk from the silk worm, by rearing practices on a commercial scale is called sericulture. It is an agro-based industry comprising three main components: i) cultivation of food plants for the silkworms, ii) rearing of silkworms, and iii) reeling and spinning of silk. The first two are agricultural and the last one is an industrial component. Only few species of silkworms are used in the sericulture industry (Table 13. 1 and Figure 13. 2).

Life cycle of *Bombyx mori*

The adult of *Bombyx mori* is about 2.5 cm in length and pale creamy white in colour. Due to heavy body and feeble wings, flight is not possible by the female moth. This moth is unisexual in nature and does not



Mulberry

Eri

Muga

Tassar

Figure 13.2 Different types of silkworms